

THE ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF TOURISM

Weighing the good and bad of one of the world's biggest industries • LEVEL A



Even when tourists behave responsibly, their sheer number can cause significant damage to popular destinations.

Many places in the world rely heavily on tourism as a key source of income and employment. Unfortunately, tourism can also be a source of serious problems, especially if it is not managed well. A huge **influx** of visitors can gradually **deplete** the beauty, uniqueness, character, environment, resources, and **social coherence** of a tourist **destination** over time. It is easy to underestimate the scale of tourism — every year, around a billion tourists take trips, which means roughly 30 tourists arrive at their destinations every single second.

Is tourism worth it? To help you think about this question, consider these two situations:

1 You are planning a holiday. A famous destination has beautiful beaches but is very crowded. What do you do?

- a** I still go — it must be popular for a good reason, and I want to see it.
- b** I look for a less crowded destination where tourism is better managed.

2 You visit another country and notice their customs are very different from yours. How do you react?

- a** I ignore local customs — I am on holiday and should be free to do what I want.
- b** I try to learn about local traditions and respect them — I am a guest in their country.

These situations show two very different attitudes towards travel. Responsible tourists try to understand the places they visit, while irresponsible ones can cause cultural clashes and damage. The article below explains the main advantages and disadvantages of tourism so you can form your own opinion.

■ ADVANTAGES OF TOURISM

- **Economic.** Tourism brings in money and can make up a significant proportion of a country's income.
- **Jobs.** Hotels, restaurants, transport, and shops all need staff — tourism creates much-needed employment.
- **Infrastructure.** Tourism provides a reason to invest in roads, rail networks, and local facilities.
- **Environmental.** It can give a place an incentive to preserve and regenerate its natural environment.
- **Cross-cultural.** It promotes international connections and builds cross-cultural understanding between people.
- **Promotional.** Tourism puts a destination on the map and raises its profile in the world.

■ DISADVANTAGES OF TOURISM

- **Environmental damage.** Erosion, pollution, and loss of natural habitats can cause permanent harm.
- **Cultural damage.** The commercialization of culture can undermine local heritage and traditions.
- **Culture clashes.** Tourists who ignore local customs and dress standards cause tension with locals.
- **Low-quality jobs.** Most tourism jobs are low-wage with little chance of advancement.
- **Seasonal work.** Tourism jobs are often insecure and seasonal — areas can be inundated then deserted.
- **Dependence.** Countries that become too focal on tourism are vulnerable to economic ruin in a downturn.

1B+

tourists travel everywhere each year

30

tourists arrive at destinations every second

10%

of world's workforce employed in tourism

\$7T

global value of tourism per year

The Cultural Benefits of Travel

When you visit another culture, you have the opportunity to be exposed to unfamiliar traditions and perspectives. Preconceptions and stereotypes can be replaced by empathy and first-hand knowledge. However, this only happens if you make an effort — merely visiting tourist sites without interacting with locals is not enough. Learning about people takes real effort and curiosity.

An important part of travelling responsibly is gaining cultural sensitivity — understanding that things which seem normal or benign to you might be offensive in another culture. Researching local customs before you travel is always a good idea. Experiencing a community's traditions, festivals, and celebrations can give you a deep and authentic insight into their heritage — but only when those traditions are genuine, not simply performed for tourists in return for money.

ACTIVITIES

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Read the article and answer True (T) or False (F).

- 1 Tourism always benefits the environment of a destination.
- 2 Tourism can create jobs in hotels, restaurants, and transport.
- 3 Most jobs created by tourism are high-skill with good career prospects.
- 4 Tourism dependence can make a country vulnerable during a downturn.
- 5 Simply visiting tourist sites is enough to gain cultural understanding.
- 6 Local traditions are sometimes performed only to entertain tourists for money.

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Match the highlighted words to their meanings.

- 1 a large number of people or things arriving at once
- 2 to use up or reduce something until very little is left
- 3 the feeling of unity and belonging within a community
- 4 the process of making money from something cultural
- 5 to damage or weaken something from the inside
- 6 flooded with too many people or things

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Read the article again and answer these questions.

- 1 Give two economic advantages of tourism for a destination.
- 2 Why does the article say that seasonal tourism jobs are a disadvantage?
- 3 What does the article say about tourists who only visit tourist sites?
- 4 Why is 'tourism dependence' described as a risk?

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Write 4–6 sentences giving your own opinion on tourism.

Use these phrases:

I think tourism is ... / One advantage is ... / However, a problem is ... / I believe tourists should ...

■ TALKING POINTS

Has tourism helped or harmed your country or city? Give examples.

Do you think tourists have a responsibility to learn about local culture? Why / Why not?

Should governments limit the number of tourists allowed in popular destinations?

Would you rather visit a famous crowded destination or a quiet unknown place?